

LSO 100 — The Canadian Short Story

Week 13: Contemporary Canada: Crisis, Technology, Environment, and the Future

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Course Overview: Where We've Been

Throughout this course, we have explored Canadian short stories that examine identity, belonging, family, culture, memory, Indigenous perspectives, immigration, humour, and the relationship between people and place. Each story has offered a unique lens on Canadian life while encouraging us to think critically about the social, cultural, and historical forces shaping individuals and communities.

As we conclude, we shift our attention to the challenges and opportunities facing **contemporary Canada** — stories where personal lives intersect with environmental change, digital technology, public perception, and uncertainty about the future.

This Week's Focus

The Story

"**Pack Ice Season**" by Bridget Canning, published in *The Walrus* (January/February 2025). Set in a quiet Newfoundland coastal community transformed by the arrival of a massive iceberg – one that many residents believe resembles Jesus Christ.

The Central Tension

As photographs spread across social media and visitors arrive to witness "Iceberg Jesus," protagonist **Joni McEntaggart** experiences the same event in an entirely different and deeply private way – seeing not a religious figure, but the face of her late husband, Gerard, who disappeared at sea.



The Emotional Centre of the Story

The contrast between the community's collective excitement and Joni's private grief becomes the emotional heart of "**Pack Ice Season.**" Canning demonstrates, with remarkable precision, that people can interpret the same event in profoundly different ways depending on their personal histories, memories, and emotional states.

❏ The iceberg never changes – but its meaning shifts entirely depending on who is looking at it.

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Connecting global issues to individual lives.

Although "**Pack Ice Season**" addresses environmental change and the growing influence of digital technology, it is ultimately a story about human experience. Canning reminds readers that major social issues are never experienced in exactly the same way by everyone. Environmental events, technological developments, and public conversations are all filtered through personal histories, memories, relationships, and emotions.



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Contemporary Canadian literature reflects a society in continuous evolution. While earlier generations of writers often focused on settlement, survival, immigration, or national identity, many twenty-first-century authors examine the **uncertainties of modern life**: climate change, digital communication, economic challenges, mental health, and rapidly shifting communities.

Rather than offering simple solutions, these stories encourage readers to ask thoughtful questions about how individuals adapt to change and how communities respond during times of uncertainty.

Defining Characteristics of Contemporary Fiction

Complexity Over Simplicity

Writers present situations where multiple perspectives coexist and no single interpretation fully explains events. Readers are invited to think critically about character motivations.

Multiple, Simultaneous Meanings

One extraordinary event – the iceberg – becomes a source of hope, faith, economic opportunity, curiosity, and emotional pain *at the same time*.

Grounded in the Familiar

Fiction reflects issues familiar to many Canadians: changing weather patterns, social media influence, the importance of tourism in smaller communities, and the emotional weight of personal loss.

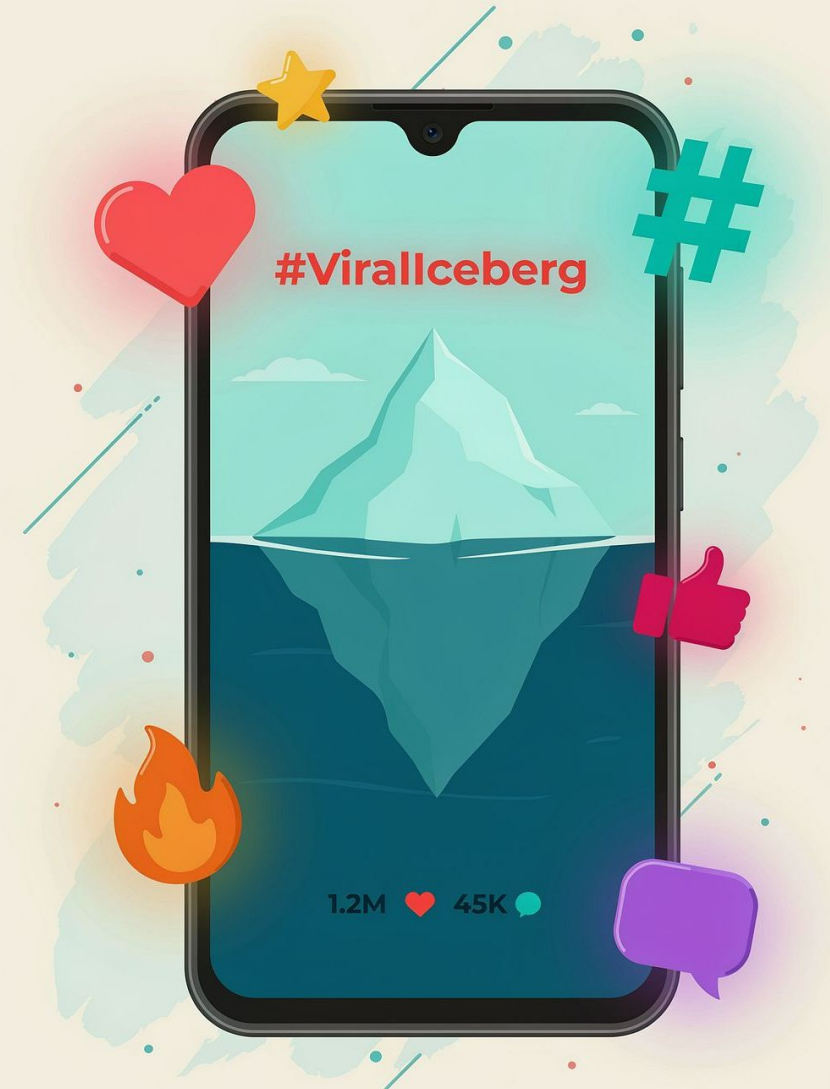


Technology, Media, and the Construction of Meaning

How the Iceberg Became Famous

The iceberg does not become a cultural phenomenon simply by appearing in the bay. It becomes famous because **photographs and social media posts** spread the image far beyond the local community. Doug Prentice's photograph, accompanied by hashtags such as #Jesus, #iceberg, and #icebergjesus, quickly attracts global attention.

News organizations, artists, religious leaders, and curious visitors all contribute to the growing public fascination with what becomes known as "**Iceberg Jesus.**" Technology does not create the iceberg — but it transforms it into a cultural event.



How Digital Media Shapes Perception



Images Before Experience

Today, people often encounter significant events first through photographs and online discussions before experiencing them directly. Digital framing determines which stories gain traction.



Meaning Made Collectively

Social media amplifies shared interpretations. The public consensus – that the iceberg looks like Jesus – is reinforced through likes, shares, and hashtags, creating a powerful collective narrative.



Personal Perception Persists

Despite thousands of people seeing a miraculous image, Joni sees something entirely different. Her interpretation is shaped by painful memory, not by popular opinion – reminding us that lived experience can override public narrative.

Commerce, Meaning, and Difficult Questions

The Tourist Economy

As visitors continue to arrive, businesses respond with souvenirs, postcards, T-shirts, food vendors, and kayak tours. These developments provide genuine economic opportunities for the community, especially in a region where such windfalls are rare.

The Harder Questions

Can something many consider sacred become a tourist attraction? Does widespread publicity change the significance of an event? Canning does not offer direct answers – she invites readers to sit with the discomfort of these tensions.

The Environment as More Than a Setting



When Landscape Becomes Character

The natural environment plays a central, active role throughout "**Pack Ice Season.**" The iceberg, the pack ice, the sea, the fog, and the changing weather are not simply background elements; they **directly influence** characters' experiences and the story's direction. This reflects a long tradition in Canadian literature where landscapes function as powerful symbols shaping identity, memory, and community.

Community Transformation

Roads crowd with visitors, local businesses surge, and residents gather at the shoreline to witness an unprecedented event.

Joni's Physical Reality

Ice accumulates around her home, icicles form along the roof, and ordinary tasks become harder — environmental conditions mirroring her internal struggle.

"Pack Ice Season": Reframing Nature

The tourism department promotes "Pack Ice Season" as a way of encouraging visitors to view the arrival of sea ice as a **seasonal attraction** rather than simply a natural occurrence or an inconvenience.

This subtle but revealing detail illustrates how communities adapt to environmental conditions by reshaping public perception. Rather than focusing solely on environmental uncertainty, the community attempts to create new opportunity by **embracing the changing landscape**. The story suggests that people continually negotiate the relationship between nature, culture, and economic survival – a negotiation that is very much alive in contemporary Canada.

Grief, Memory, and the Power of Perspective



Joni's Private World

While the community celebrates what many believe to be a miraculous sight, Joni experiences the iceberg as a painful reminder of her husband, **Gerard**, who disappeared at sea following an argument. Her grief is not simple, and it is not shared. For everyone else, the iceberg represents hope, faith, or economic opportunity. For Joni, it is an unavoidable symbol of **unresolved loss**.

As readers learn more about Joni's memories, the complexity of her situation deepens: their marriage was marked by emotional control, criticism, and intimidation. Even after his disappearance, Gerard's voice continues to surface in her thoughts — criticizing her decisions and making her doubt herself.



The Complexity of Grief

Sadness

The loss of a partner, however complicated, leaves a profound absence in everyday life.

Relief

The end of an emotionally controlling relationship can bring unexpected and guilt-laden relief.

Guilt

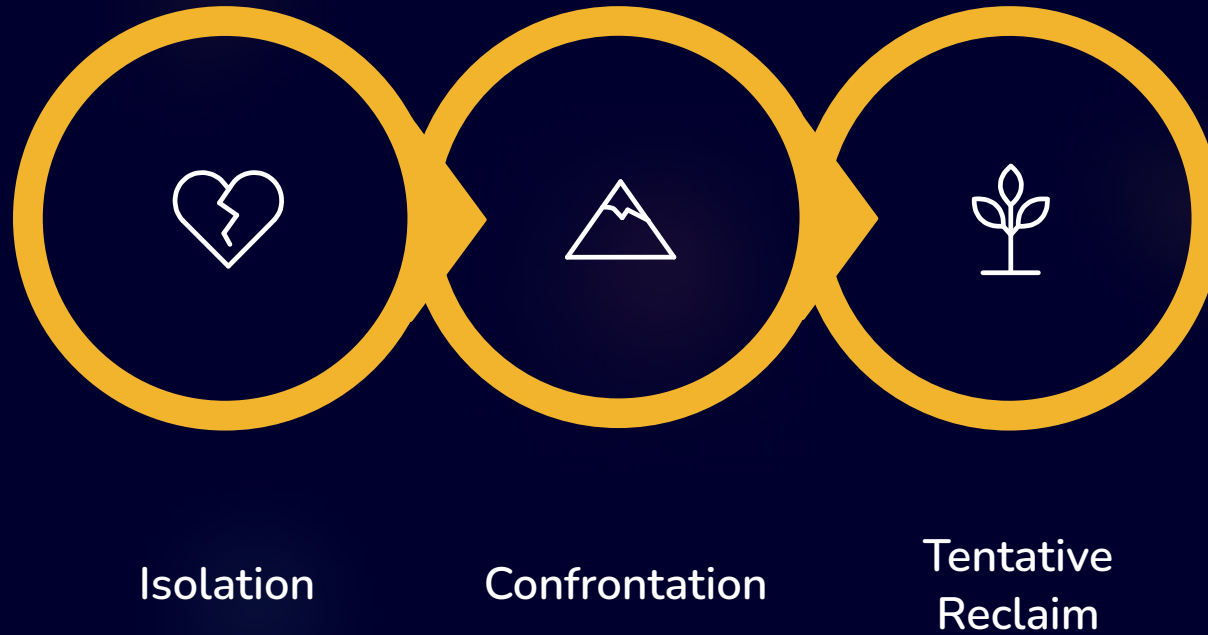
Joni carries the weight of unresolved conflict from the night Gerard disappeared.

Anger

Years of criticism and emotional control leave legitimate anger, even in grief.

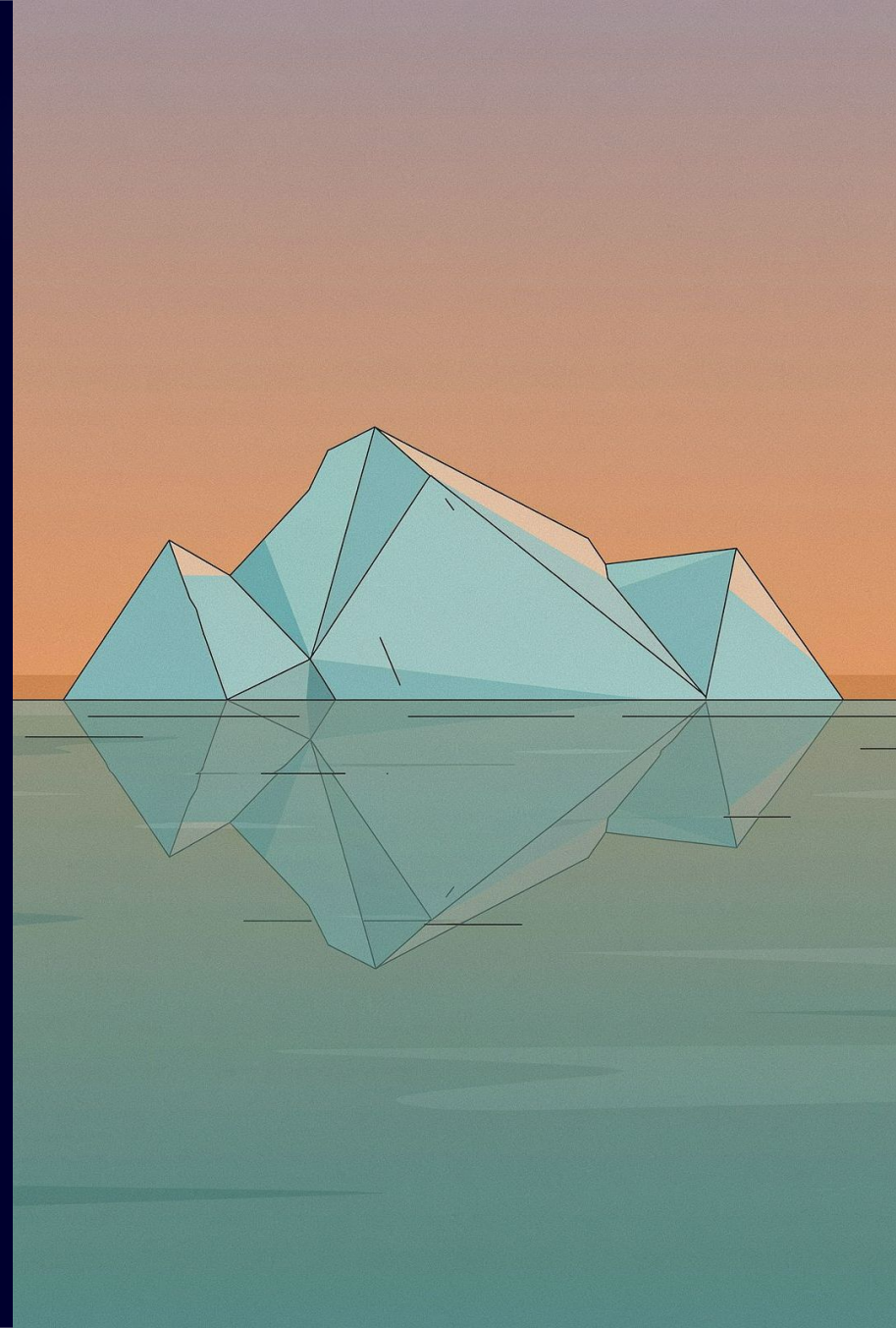
Canning carefully avoids portraying grief as a simple or predictable process. These conflicting emotions coexist within Joni, making her one of the most realistic and compelling characters in recent Canadian short fiction.

Healing as a Non-Linear Journey



Rather than presenting grief as something that can simply be overcome, "**Pack Ice Season**" suggests that healing involves learning to live with painful memories while *gradually* reclaiming one's independence and identity. The path is neither straight nor predictable.

Symbolism and Literary Techniques

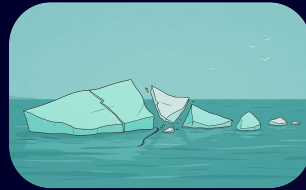


Key Symbols in "Pack Ice Season"



The Iceberg

To the community: "Iceberg Jesus" — hope, faith, miracles, and opportunity.
To Joni: the face of Gerard. The iceberg is unchanged; meaning shifts entirely with the observer.



The Pack Ice

It traps the iceberg in the bay, just as Joni feels trapped by memory. When it begins to break apart, readers sense the first possibility of emotional release.



Shane the Cat

Shane represents companionship and emotional security. His disappearance and frightened return mirrors Joni's own wounds — both have survived, both carry lasting scars requiring patience and trust to heal.

Imagery and the Newfoundland Landscape

Sensory Richness

Canning creates vivid, immersive descriptions of Newfoundland's coastal landscape. Readers can almost *feel* the freezing wind, *hear* the cracking sea ice, and *visualize* the enormous iceberg dominating the bay. These sensory details are not decorative – they actively shape atmosphere and meaning.

Landscape as Emotional Mirror

The harsh winter conditions, the ice-encrusted home, the dangerous roads – all reinforce Joni's internal state. In the tradition of Canadian literature, the physical environment is never simply a backdrop. It actively participates in the emotional and thematic work of the narrative, reflecting back the internal world of its characters.



Community, Tourism, and Contemporary Society

Community Resilience and Its Costs

As visitors arrive from across the province and beyond, local residents quickly recognize opportunities: food trucks, souvenir shops, kayak tours, postcards, and T-shirts appear almost immediately. The community demonstrates **remarkable creativity and adaptability** in responding to unexpected circumstances — a quality that speaks to the resilience of small communities across Atlantic Canada.

At the same time, Canning encourages readers to notice the costs. Tourism creates congestion, noise, litter, and a loss of privacy. Visitors admire the iceberg without recognizing that it represents something **deeply painful** for someone living directly across from it. Public celebration can inadvertently erase individual experience.





Newfoundland Identity and Sense of Place

Place as Identity

Newfoundland is more than the backdrop of this narrative – it is an **essential part of the story's identity**. The fishing industry, the close-knit community, the church, the harsh winters, and the deep relationship between people and the ocean all contribute to the story's authenticity and emotional resonance.

The Sea: Gift and Danger

The ocean provides employment, beauty, recreation, and spiritual meaning – but it also claims lives. Gerard's disappearance while fishing reminds readers that the sea has always been both generous and unpredictable.

Culture and Community

Canning captures local humour, neighbourly relationships, community gatherings, and the importance of storytelling – all essential features of Newfoundland identity that enrich the narrative's texture.



Looking Back on the Course

As we conclude our study of Canadian short fiction, "**Pack Ice Season**" draws together many of the themes explored throughout the semester. Earlier stories examined identity, family, belonging, Indigenous perspectives, immigration, community, and memory. Canning's story demonstrates that these themes remain deeply relevant in contemporary Canada while introducing new concerns: technology, environmental change, tourism, and the challenge of public perception.

Themes Across the Semester



"**Pack Ice Season**" serves as a powerful culminating text precisely because it holds so many of these threads simultaneously – making it an ideal lens through which to reflect on the entire course.

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The same iceberg becomes a miracle to some, an economic opportunity to others, and a painful reminder of loss for Joni. Through these different interpretations, Canning demonstrates that our understanding of the world is often shaped by our own histories and experiences.

Literature rarely provides simple answers. It encourages us to consider multiple perspectives, question our assumptions, and recognize the irreducible complexity of human experience. This is not a weakness – it is literature's greatest gift to its readers.

Key Takeaways

01

Perspective Shapes Meaning

The same event can carry radically different significance depending on personal history, memory, and emotional experience.

02

Technology Constructs Reality

Digital media does not merely report on events – it actively shapes which interpretations gain traction and which are marginalized.

03

Environment is Never Neutral

In Canadian literature, landscape is a living participant in the story, shaping identity, emotion, and community response.

04

Grief is Complex and Non-Linear

Healing rarely follows a predictable path. Literature helps us extend empathy to experiences we may not share directly.

05

Literature Connects the Global and the Personal

Contemporary fiction transforms abstract social issues into intimate human experience – its most enduring and essential quality.

A Final Thought

Literature is not simply about telling stories.

It is about exploring what it means to be human during times of uncertainty and change. Through its memorable characters, vivid setting, and thoughtful symbolism, "**Pack Ice Season**" challenges readers to reflect on grief, hope, community, and the many ways people find meaning in the world around them. As Canada continues to confront new environmental, technological, and social realities, literature remains an **essential space for reflection, dialogue, and imagination.**



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